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MORE BARK, More Byte

Holy men, freak accidents, movie trivia and sporting gossip, all delivered in the aggressive tone of an investigative reporter, form a noisy segment of the Rs 25,000-crore TV industry

By Asha Kasbekar |

When Chinese tycoon Li Ka-Shing launched Star TV from Hong Kong, little did he imagine that it would unleash a cultural tsunami in India. His intention had been to offer high-profile American programmes to the newly rich citizens of South-east and East Asia, which would be paid for by the advertising of luxury goods. Unfortunately, the Asian tigers collapsed, but thanks to the Southern footprint of AsiaSat1 that covered the entire south Asian subcontinent, the programmes found favour in India, a nation

starved of real entertainment.

Satellite television, the love child of an unplanned union between India's economic reforms of 1991 and the arrival of the first satellite channel in 1992, turns 18 in 2010. But has it really come of age? From just one satellite channel in 1992, there are about 417 satellite channels in less than two decades. One of the most curious features of this exponential growth has been the proliferation of news channels. There are currently around 73 dedicated channels offering 24-hour news and current affairs programmes. Another 95 are waiting to be added in the coming year.

Dubbed as a visionary, former

NEWS MAY HAVE MIGRATED TO THE INTERNET IN THE REST OF THE WORLD. BUT IN INDIA, IT WAS REVIVED AND REDEFINED ON TV

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE TO TV

- It's a medium that's small physically, large otherwise. With 130 million TV households in India, its reach and impact is phenomenal.
- With 417 channels on air, news and entertainment are jostling for space. If there are 73 news channels loading us with information, there are 67 general entertainment channels.
- Women enjoy a monopoly in this medium. *Saas, bahu, beti* and *behen*—they are all that and more.